

TOWARD PUBLIC SPHERE INTERCOLLEGIATE POLICY DEBATE: THE PATH TO PARTICIPATION?

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Introduction & Justification

As part of an NCA-sponsored debate exchange program, each year Baylor University hosts the British National debate team for a public debate on its campus. Each year, the British assuredly navigate a topic of their opponent's choosing, and usually proceed to handily win the public vote at the conclusion of the exchange. Having witnessed this phenomenon several times, and having failed to remedy the situation through a series of pre-debate coaching sessions on how to adapt to a public audience, I began to wonder what secret the British debaters were keeping. The answer soon became clear, as one of our overseas visitors explained to me over dinner. In his opinion, American-style policy debate is simply too fast, too quote-dependent, and too overly competitive. Having been immersed in fast, research-oriented American policy debate for over 20 years as a competitor or a coach, my initial reaction was to defend our activity with the commonly made arguments about fast-speaking as an art form (Rickert, 1978), the in-depth education and research skills that come with top-level competition in the activity, the ways in which policy debate trains future legislators, attorneys, and policymakers, and the pedagogical benefits of advanced critical thinking that are associated with this type of debate (Harrigan, 2008, p.7; Rude, 2004, p.271). While I still believe that these justifications are legitimate, I began to wonder if there was indeed a link between the

decline in the number of policy debate programs and the advent of the rapid delivery style that characterizes contemporary intercollegiate policy debate. Further, I questioned how alternative styles of policy debate might impact participation in the activity.

The goal of this article is threefold: first, I aim to identify the factors of contemporary intercollegiate policy debate that contribute to its characterization as a 'technical sphere' activity. I argue that the 'technical' nature of most modern policy debate functions to discourage participation in the activity, and to further alienate the public audience from meaningful participation (or even comprehension). I argue that the college debate community must evolve into a more inclusive public organization, or face extinction. Second, I hope to identify some of the ways in which non-traditional approaches to policy debate are breaking into the realm of the possible and moving debate back toward a more public communication event. I also argue that recent popular films such as *The Great Debaters* and the high school debate documentary *Resolved* have shed new light on the ways in which policy debate might evolve into a more inclusive community of public intellectuals. Finally, I revisit and reexamine potential solutions to the problem of decreased participation in intercollegiate policy debate. None of the solutions I review and identify are silver-bullet answers to the multiple dilemmas facing American college policy debate, nor are any of them completely my own. Rather, they have emerged from numerous conversations and interactions with(in) the debate community. It is important to remember that I am writing this essay from inside the 'establishment', as someone who is torn between advocating preservation of intercollegiate policy debate as it is (speed, expert testimony, narrow topics and all!), and identifying and criticizing what I believe could be our undoing as a discourse community.

Intercollegiate Policy Debate in the ‘Technical Sphere’

Contemporary intercollegiate policy debate has evolved into a highly specialized ‘technical sphere’ activity, complete with its own normative rule structures, distinctive language, and evidence-heavy, rapid style of delivery. Indeed, the debate community shares a “special kind of understanding” that informs the style and substance of policy debate rounds (Goodnight, 1982, p.3). Like many communities whose members share similar goals and interests, policy debate has developed its own shorthand jargon and even a specialized method of note-taking (called ‘flowing’) designed to accommodate and account for the rapid delivery that characterizes and pervades most modern policy rounds. The evidence presented by debaters (and accepted by most judges) in NDT/CEDA debate rounds privileges “a limited number of experts at the expense of marginalizing certain voices” (Preston, 2006, p.168). That is to say, quoting expert testimony or literature, in mass quantity, and at speeds of 300 words-per-minute is the norm in American college debate. An enriched understanding of the ways in which a discourse community prioritizes and assigns value to experts is critical to uncovering new ways in which the debate community could evolve. As Willard (2006) argued, although “expert testimony is a rhetorical enterprise” whose import and impact are discursively negotiable, communities are nonetheless “organized around the conservation of a trusted body of knowledge; they tend toward conservatism; they resist change in principle” (p.228; p.230). Further, before each debate season begins, the community agrees upon a year-long topic in order to “narrow the range of permissible subject matter while all the while requiring more specialized forms of reasoning” (Goodnight, 1982, p.3).

It is easy to see how “intercollegiate policy debate has become remarkably isolated and esoteric”, and equally simple to understand why the activity is shrinking: “because so few people can

participate in these debates, *virtually* no one observes them; untrained spectators are often baffled” (English, et al, 2007, p.223). One wonders what happened to the 12,000 students and 700 high school educators who have been trained in the wildly successful Urban Debate Leagues that began to spring up nationwide in the late 1990s (Preston, 2006, p.157). It seems logical to assume that a strong percentage of those students would choose to continue their policy debating at the college level, but this has not been the case. Perhaps the dearth in participation can be explained by remembering that high school policy debate practices closely mirror, and indeed are modeled from the intercollegiate policy circuit. Additionally, “what goes on in national circuit debating has a profound influence on what occurs in the urban debate leagues” (Preston, 2006, p.161). Given this trend, it seems clear that “learning rapid fire delivery” may be “causing more of the UDL target students to quit debate than to stay” (Preston, 2006, p.168). While acknowledging the intellectual and pedagogical benefits of this approach to policy debate, English et al (2007) opines that “the isolation of this form of debate both protects it from criticism and prevents it from having a broader social effect” (p.223). Goodnight (1982) warns that the insular nature of technical sphere discourse communities, like intercollegiate policy debate, risks the steady erosion of the public sphere. When public participation is devalued and diminished by the overreliance on specialized forms of expert knowledge, the public becomes separated from the argumentative means by which they might influence “issues of significant public consequence” (Goodnight, p.5).

Participation in intercollegiate policy debate is declining, and that trend is likely to continue unless

reforms are undertaken to make the activity more appealing to the public. However, a solution must be uncovered that balances the need for modification with the inherent advantages associated with this particular style of debate. A number of communication scholars have offered ways to reverse the evaporation of support, and several spoke directly of the central need for evidentiary and delivery-based reforms. In a prophetic essay that seemed to foreshadow the advent of rapid delivery and hyper-technical evidentiary standards in American policy debate (as well as the rise of Parliamentary-style debate in American colleges), Baird (1923) argued that while he found the British debate methods to be less rigorous than the American process, he believed that the more formal and elocutionary nature of the British style could provide a useful model for the Yanks. Thus, even in the early part of the twentieth century (before the era of 'modern' debate began in 1947) concern was growing among influential debate thinkers that the American style was evolving in a manner that rewarded debaters who relied more heavily on the expert testimony of others than on their own persuasive abilities and public speaking skills.

Competitive pressures to win debates by presenting more evidence than one's opponent (thus causing them to 'drop' or leave key arguments unanswered) grew. By the late 1960s and early 1970s, the progression of intercollegiate policy debate toward rapid delivery style was completely underway. Concerns about the impact of this style on both participation in the activity, and its pedagogical usefulness sprang up concurrently. Rickerts (1978) recognized the academic and artistic benefits of fast policy debate, but conceded that the very nature of the delivery would limit its audience and discourage public participation. Morello (1980) echoed the warnings about fast speaking, and pointed to reforms in the topic selection process and tournament format as ways to combat the trend toward 'spreading'. While I believe Morello accurately diagnosed the problem (fast delivery), I disagree with his

assessment about the solutions in this case. While reforms in tournament structure, timing, and topic might temporarily increase participation in the activity, they would not be sufficient to eliminate the normative trend toward fast speaking, which I believe is the central cause of the decline of participation. There is also the possibility that topics which were deliberately chosen to appeal to broader audiences, and thus wider in scope and boundary, would simply be co-opted by the policy debate community and used for competitive advantage (ample ground for 'new' affirmatives, minor-repair affirmatives, etc) rather than to embrace an opportunity to genuinely increase public involvement. The dominance of rapid delivery prompted Herbeck (1989) to argue that the competitive component of college policy debate should be secondary to the goal of increasing the educational value of the activity for its participants. While Herbeck's suggestion may be painful to those debaters (and coaches) whose presence in the community is motivated by the competitive aspects of the activity, I believe it represents the foundational type of solution that is needed at this juncture. Debate should be competitive, and it should be hard. But by that I mean to argue that a balance must be located between an activity bereft of research and strategy, where anyone off the street can participate and offer their unwarranted and unsupported opinions, and an activity that is so insulated, high-tech, and win-driven that it marginalizes those who are not willing to learn how to talk fast and sacrifice their personal, academic, and social well-being. The following suggestions represent a potential path toward increased participation in intercollegiate policy debate.

Toward 'Public Sphere' Intercollegiate Policy Debate

I have identified a trio of factors that contribute to a dangerous decline in policy debate participation at the college level: rapid delivery, evidentiary standards, and overwhelming competitive pressures to win. One promising alternative that begins to address these problems is the emergence of performance-based policy

debate in which students often still advocate policy solutions, but rely on different types of evidence and delivery. This approach to debate emphasizes personal experience, cognizance of social location, and the uncovering of privilege that often itself hinders participation in debate. Rather than relying on what Willard (2006) called “arguing by quoting”, debaters use their own lived experiences to make arguments about the debate topic (p.229). Clarity and persuasion are foregrounded in this type of debate, where the goal is to convince a judge, rather than to overwhelm one’s opponent and win the debate on a dropped argument. The recent competitive success of debate programs which focus on the performative style of debate attests to the power of this movement. While critics have argued that performance-based debate is more theater than policy laboratory, these charges obscure the undeniable impact that this approach has had on the activity. The development of high school UDLs also demonstrate an effort to broaden the borders of the community, and in some programs, to widen the scope of what constitutes acceptable evidence and styles. However, once those students get to the college level, they are often forced to ‘play by the rules’ or attend one of the few colleges whose debate program is geared toward increased participation rather than solely on competitive success.

Several recent films and documentaries have followed the rise of performance-based debate, and indeed, this mass media exposure has even led to the establishment of several new college debate programs. New debate teams at Southern Methodist, Oklahoma City University, and at Austin College, to name a few, have sprung up at least partially in response to renewed interest in the activity generated by films such as *The Great Debaters*, a major motion picture starring Denzel Washington, and *Resolved*, a documentary that contrasts traditional policy debate with the performative style. Indeed, the re-establishment of the program at OCU was inspired by *The Great Debaters*, in which OCU is portrayed as one of the first minority debate teams to

compete against other programs like the one at Wiley College, which is featured in the film. These films represent a way to begin to bridge the gap between the public and the college debate community. Recently, as I was on the phone making hotel reservations for an upcoming debate tournament at Georgia State University, the young woman who was confirming our arrival stopped in the middle of our exchange and asked if what we did was “like that movie, *the Great Debaters*”. She then asked several more questions about the activity, and remarked that “it must be really different to see a debate live in person”. She couldn’t be more correct. Though I invited her to come down to the campus and watch some rounds, part of me worried that she would wander into a traditional policy debate and be predictably baffled. If no one pointed her to a debate involving Louisville, or Towson State, or Fullerton, she probably wouldn’t be sticking around for too long. Mass media and public exposure of this sort is somewhat foreign to the intercollegiate debate community, and it is my sincere hope that the style of debate portrayed in these films has a real impact on debate practice and participation.

A second potential solution worthy of mention is the suggestion of Rowland and Deatherage (1988) who argued that rapid delivery was directly responsible for the decline in intercollegiate policy debate participation. However, rather than making appeals based on the need for decreased competitiveness and increased pedagogical focus, Rowland and Deatherage indicated a need to harness the over-competitive nature of the activity as a way to change it from within. They advocated judging reforms that increased rewards for clarity and persuasion, and punishment for rapid delivery and ‘spreading’ for its own sake. Their argument was that the real power for changes in the style of debate rests with the judges who control wins and losses, as well as speaker points. If judges were to enforce norms that rewarded persuasion and less reliance on speed and sheer volume of evidence, then debaters who wanted to win would be forced to adapt. While this suggestion

seems utopian in that it would be difficult to gain a consensus amongst college debate judges regarding the exact nature and structure of these proposed changes, I believe that judges are perhaps the strongest potential agents for change in the activity. It never ceases to amaze me when debaters, coaches, and judges argue that “the activity is for the students” as a way to gloss over unhealthy debate practices that creep into the game. This activity belongs as much (or more) to the people who dedicate their lives to teaching argumentation and debate, and it is with the wisdom of experience and deep-seated love for the game that we ‘dinosaurs’ voice these complaints. Before his recent passing in December of 2009, Scott Deatherage had begun to embody and enact these proposed correctives in both his coaching, and in the pedagogically-centered vision of debate that he espoused as the Executive Director of the National Association of Urban Debate Leagues (NAUDL). It speaks volumes that Deatherage, the coach of an astonishing seven NDT National Champions from 1994-2005, would make these types of arguments about the over-competitive nature of debate. While the Northwestern debate program certainly reaped the rewards of his hard work, and perhaps because of his position at the center of the research and coaching apparatus, Deatherage himself recognized the inherent long-term risks of such an exhaustive approach to debate.

A variant on the plan put forth by Rowland and Deatherage might be for judges to simply reward slow but persuasive speakers with wins, without necessarily enforcing card limits or other draconian measures that could negatively impact the educational benefits of policy debate. Examples abound of successful debaters who were not blessed (or cursed!) with the physical ability to speak at fast rates. While some of these students certainly lost debates on ‘dropped arguments’, many of them also won debates because of an advanced ability to be convincing, and to deploy smart analytical arguments to defeat a mountain of expert evidence presented by their opponents. I believe that many judges probably

already employ this calculus when deciding debates, but there are also many who remain perfectly willing to vote a team down because they were simply 'out-carded'.

A third possible solution to the problem of participation starts at the high school level. As I mentioned earlier, the high school debate circuit closely mirrors the style and substance of intercollegiate policy debate. Thousands of high school students attend debate workshops in the summer, and more often than not, the instructors and 'lab' leaders at these workshops are college debaters or coaches. I believe that as educators, we have an obligation to teach these students how to effectively communicate and make arguments in a cogent, comprehensible manner. Whether we acknowledge it or not, we are role models for young high school debaters, and as such, we have immense power to influence their perceptions about what constitutes good debate. Rather than teaching debaters to do speed drills, we should focus on clarity drills and the development of solid critical thinking and analytical skills. As a veteran of many high school debate workshops, I must admit my own complicity in the perpetuation of fast debate. Indeed, the mantra that I usually tried to instill in my students was that "Speed Kills". Over the years I have come to see this as a destructive and verbally aggressive educational construct. While I still teach my college debaters that the ability to 'cover the spread' is an integral component of competitive success, I also stress the importance of never sacrificing one's clarity for the sake of reading a few more pieces of evidence. I believe that if high school debate workshops actively tried to downplay the importance of fast delivery, we might begin to see subtle changes in the makeup of the activity.

I borrow my final suggestion from an idea that was initiated by the late Ross Smith, the former debate coach at Wake Forest University. Following the attacks against the United States on September 11th, 2001, Ross adopted changes to the schedule of the Wake Forest college debate tournament, one of the nation's oldest and largest such events. Because of his belief in the power of

debate to influence real-world decision-making, Ross set aside one preliminary round at the tournament for teams to debate a topic related to terrorism and its implications. Prior to the tournament, after registration on Friday evening, the Wake Forest squad hosted a public debate in which former college debaters talked (slowly) about the recent attacks and the possible range of U.S. responses. By all accounts, this experiment was a resounding success. I believe that this model could be adopted at college debate tournaments of all sizes, and could focus on timely issues other than the agreed-upon year-long resolution. For example, this year it might make sense to host a public forum debate regarding the economic crisis, or a debate about the potentiality of a public health crisis from H1N1 flu. While the college debate topic is usually centered on a timely policy problem that is not always the case (see the Indian Country topic from 2000, or the Commander-In-Chief topic from the early 1990s). Public debates on –such as immigration--controversies with relevance to mass audiences may very well be one path to increased participation in the activity. While debates about increasing federal control over Indian lands might indeed be socially relevant, that sort of college debate topic is simply not as accessible as a topic that held broader interest for larger segments of the population.

Indeed, the passing of both Ross Smith and Scott Deatherage has brought into sharp relief the need for reforms in intercollegiate policy debate. In many ways, both of these luminary coaches “died for the cause”: too many sleepless nights researching and strategizing; too many fast-food meals at 11pm following prelims; too much stress over wins and losses (the bottom line); and not enough relaxation or decompression time. The vision of these two legendary debate coaches is for a more humane, more intellectually inclusive, and more public form of college debate. While both Smith and Deatherage clearly had begun to make the intellectual shift in this direction prior to their passing, it is a shame of tremendous magnitude that they will not be with us to

witness the beginnings of a new broad-based self-consciousness in the debate community that is more cognizant of its own human footprint.

Conclusions & Implications

For many years, the law school at Baylor University offered a full-tuition scholarship named after Leon Jaworski, a Baylor graduate who helped to litigate the Watergate case in the 1970s. This award was reserved solely for an incoming student who had demonstrated success and aptitude in intercollegiate policy debate competition. Until recently, the instructors at the Baylor law school believed that policy debate was an appropriate training ground for future attorneys and policymakers. That perception changed last summer when the application process for the Jaworski scholarship was modified. No longer simply based on LSAT scores and an applicant's win-loss percentage in debate, now students must submit a videotape of themselves in action in a debate round in order to be eligible for the award. When I was asked to meet with the professors at the law school to view the videotaped applications, I gladly (and proudly) accepted. What I saw in that meeting was a wake-up call for me, and indeed, for the teachers at the Baylor law school. We viewed four videos in all, two were from college policy debaters, and the other two were from debaters who competed in Parliamentary and Public Forum styles of debate. The policy debate applicants were met with laughter, scorn, and ridicule when they appeared onscreen speaking at fast rates of speed, and were indeed incomprehensible to everyone in the room but myself. I was asked repeatedly if this was the accepted style in college policy debate, and while I did my best to defend our activity, I ended up feeling silly and embarrassed by what was displayed. Needless to say, the policy debaters who applied for the scholarship were rejected in favor of the other applicants, whose videotaped submissions demonstrated a slow, controlled, persuasive style of delivery. The Jaworski scholarship is no longer reserved for students

with experience in intercollegiate policy debate, and while many former Jaworski scholars have voiced their opposition to this development, I do not think it will change anytime soon. For the decision-makers at the Baylor Law School, the in-depth research skills required for success in policy debate, while desirable, were outweighed by the degree to which those students would have to 'unlearn' most of the speaking patterns that they had developed as policy debaters.

This experience brought into sharp relief the degree to which what we teach our debaters can have a lasting (and potentially negative) impact on the lives of our students. As debate educators, and as argumentation scholars, I believe that we have a moral obligation to impart the values of persuasion and sound reasoning to our students. We have a duty to produce citizens who are prepared to participate in meaningful public discourse. Making great debaters entails preparing them for advocacy in the real world, and not solely from the penthouse of the proverbial ivory tower. I believe that a shift in how intercollegiate debaters speak and deliver arguments is critical to avoid a more precipitous decline in participation, and it is my hope that this essay has helped to uncover and explicate some of the ways in which we might begin the transition to a more publicly accessible form of intercollegiate policy debate.

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